PROFESSIONAL PORTFOLIO

Dilara D. Akgüner.

PhD · Post Doc · Human Behaviour · Organisational Development · Wellbeing & Excellence · Modern Policy for the Future of Work & Skills

Australian citizen | Active AGSVA Baseline security clearance

Executive Summary

Summary

I’m an organisational development, strategy and wellbeing professional with a PhD in urban political sociology and a deep interest in human behaviour, social systems and how organisations evolve.

My career spans Commonwealth and State Government, university research, international programs and consulting. Across these environments, I’ve worked at the intersection of people, policy, strategy and organisational change—helping organisations navigate complexity, build stronger systems and create better ways of working.

Focus

I focus on the relationship between people, culture and organisational performance.

I believe organisations work best when people understand their roles, feel supported and have the structures, leadership and relationships they need to succeed.

My work brings together organisational design, workforce wellbeing, governance and practical change to create environments that are effective and supportive of people.

Capabilities

- Strategy and transformation: Turning complex challenges into clear priorities, practical plans and achievable change.
- Organisational development: Improving structures, governance, accountability and ways of working so that people and teams can perform effectively.
- Engagement and collaboration: Bringing stakeholders together, navigating different perspectives and building shared understanding.
- Research and evidence: Connecting insights from human behaviour, social science and data to inform better decisions.

- Implementation and improvement: Translating ideas into workable frameworks, operating models and sustainable improvements.
- Workplace culture and wellbeing: Supporting psychologically safe, inclusive and resilient organisations through thoughtful systems and leadership.

I bring an interdisciplinary perspective, combining analytical thinking with creativity, emotional intelligence and an understanding of how people respond to change.

Philosophy & motivation

Healthy organisations are designed, not simply hoped for.

Sustainable performance depends on more than policies, processes and performance measures. It requires clear structures, inclusive leadership, meaningful relationships and a workplace culture where people feel valued, supported and able to contribute.

I believe people should be able to succeed at work without hiding who they are or fearing mistakes. Trust, psychological safety and accountability shape how people participate, learn and work together.

My motivation is to understand why organisations get stuck, then design practical systems, structures and ways of working that enable lasting improvement. Wellbeing influences retention, innovation and organisational resilience, and belongs at the centre of organisational decisions.

For me, organisational wellbeing and organisational effectiveness are fundamentally connected.

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Career Portfolio

Cross-functional background across organisational design, human behaviour, public sector transformation, governance, data, communications and policy. Experience includes leading framework development, organisational readiness, emerging technology governance, quality assurance, data governance, stakeholder engagement and culture-focused reform.

Career history demonstrates a strong pattern of building structure in complex environments, translating evidence into practical frameworks, and supporting organisations through change, risk and operational improvement.

Public Service

Sabbatical & DEWR Initiative | Research, Digital Strategy & Communications | Intellectual Design AU

Sydney / Remote

DEWR initiative: January 2025 – March 2026 · Intellectual Design AU: 2026–Present

A sabbatical encompassing a Department of Employment and Workplace Relations (DEWR) initiative and the development of Intellectual Design AU, connecting emerging technology governance, responsible AI, research translation and digital communications.

- Developed governance approaches for emerging technology, responsible AI and future-of-work policy through the DEWR initiative.
- Advise on AI strategy, research translation, digital products and change communications for complex public-sector and organisational challenges.
- Develop practical knowledge products and narrative platforms, including Know ThyAI Rights, Science Story Service, Knowledge Dashboard concepts and domain synthesis tools.
- Translate technical, social and regulatory material into accessible content, executive-ready recommendations and audience-centred experiences.

Department of Infrastructure, Transport, Regional Development, Communications, Sport and the Arts — Director, Research Lead and Framework Development

Sydney | April 2026 – August 2026

Led research and framework development to strengthen organisational capability, governance, role clarity and cross-functional alignment.

Department of Industry, Science and Research — Assistant Director, Business Grants and Funding

Sydney | January 2024 – December 2024

Managed business grants and funding programs, supporting transparent assessment, program governance and industry outcomes.

Australian Digital Health Agency — Assistant Director, Corporate Strategic Communications

Sydney | 2022–2023

Led strategic communications translating complex digital health priorities into clear public, stakeholder and executive messaging.

Victorian Department of Families, Fairness and Housing — Senior Manager, Data Governance

Melbourne | 2021–2022

Managed data governance frameworks supporting privacy, data quality, ethical use and evidence-informed decision-making.

Victorian Department of Health — Senior Manager, Quality Assurance, COVID Response

Melbourne | 2020–2021

Led quality assurance and operational improvement work during the COVID response, supporting service delivery and public health outcomes.

Academia

University of Melbourne — Urban Sociologist

Melbourne | 2019

Conducted research on urban social dynamics, cohesion, inequality and community development.

UNDP and SeeD — Co-developer, SCORE Index: Social Connectedness and Resilience Index

Nicosia | 2017–2018

Provided urban affairs research and advice across social impact, policy development and stakeholder engagement.

Australian Endeavour Award Fellow, Humboldt University — Social Cohesion and Digital Storytelling

Berlin | 2016–2017

Co-developed a social connectedness and resilience index measuring urban cohesion, resilience and peacebuilding dynamics.

Academic teaching, PhD research, policy centre roles, international development, migration, security and humanitarian programs

Australia, Türkiye, Italy, and Europe | 2004–2015

Conducted postdoctoral research on social cohesion, digital storytelling and social psychology in urban centres.

Research and Policy

Held teaching, research, centre leadership, fellowship and editorial roles across academic and policy institutions.

IOM / UNHCR — Case Officer, Lead Investigator and Writer

Managed complex migration and protection cases, including investigation, reporting and international mission work.

EU / İKGV, Human Resource Development Foundation — Project Officer

Delivered health training projects for first responders, coordinating partners, resources and program outcomes.

UN Security / IOM — Head Security Assistant

Supported security operations for the first out-of-country voting for the Iraqi elections, including protocols, logistics and team coordination.

Education

Communication & Visual Arts — Graduate Diploma

Victorian College of the Arts, Melbourne University | Melbourne, Australia | January 2020 – December 2022

Social Psychology — Postdoctoral Research

Kadir Has University | January 2016 – December 2016

Urban Political Sociology — Doctor of Philosophy (PhD)

Monash University | January 2008 – December 2015

International Relations — Master of Arts (Honours)

University of Sydney | January 2003 – December 2004

International Relations and Public Relations — Bachelor of Arts, Double Degree

Deakin University | January 1999 – December 2003

Selected Products and Projects

Know ThyAI Rights

Interactive tool helping people understand and navigate rights and responsibilities related to artificial intelligence.

Science Story Service

Narrative platform translating complex scientific material into accessible public formats.

Knowledge Dashboard and Domain Insight Weave

Concept products for exploring socio-technical systems, policy domains and evidence relationships.

SCORE Social Cohesion and Urban Resilience Index

Cross-jurisdictional evidence framework connecting social data, urban insight and policy recommendations.

The Library

Research repository and synthesis portal.

Research, governance and creative projects

The City Index and Living Lab Blueprint

Delos Delta | 2017–2018

Developed urban measurement and advisory work, including a Living Lab Blueprint for collaborative innovation and local government planning.

Responsible AI and emerging technology governance

Governance · Readiness · Capability

Co-designed governance approaches, risk communication and practical decision-making tools to support responsible technology adoption in public sector settings.

Research translation and digital storytelling

Research · Communications · Creative practice

Translated complex evidence into executive briefings, visual narratives, learning materials and public-facing digital stories.

Awards & Fellowships

Monash Vice-Chancellor Scholarship; Australian Postgraduate Award; Australian Endeavour Award; international research and teaching fellowships.

ACMI X Fellowship

2017

Digital sociology and storytelling.

Endeavour Executive Fellowship

2016–2017

International research fellowship hosted at Humboldt and Kadir Has Universities.

Humboldt University Summer Seminar Fellowship

2016

Social struggle and globalisation.

Australian Multicultural Foundation Grant

2015

Reverse migration documentary exploring the experiences of Australian-Turks in Istanbul.

Associate Dean PhD Research Award

Monash University | 2014

Australian Postgraduate Award

Monash University | 2012–2015

Research Travel Award

Monash University | 2012

International research collaboration.

Research Travel Scholarship

Deakin University | 2002

Publications

Selected research, policy writing and creative publications exploring social cohesion, human behaviour, technology and public life.

Research & Policy

The Accountability Mirage

2024–2026 | Substack

A socio-technical and de-colonial critique of AI governance.

A Strategic Framework for Responsible AI

2024–2026 | Substack

The role of the AI ethicist in modern governance.

Towards Inclusive, Participatory and Sustainable Futures

2024–2026 | Substack

The role of technology in bridging social divides.

Human Behaviour and Cognitive AI

2024–2026 | Substack

Research translation on behaviour, cognition and emerging technology.

Harnessing AI to Improve Access to Justice in Australian Courts

2024–2026 | Substack

Public-facing writing on technology, institutions and access.

Understanding AI’s Role in Human Behavioural Evolution

2024–2026 | Substack

Social Neuroscience: How Our Brains and Relationships Shape One Another

2024–2026 | Substack

Rethinking Work for a Neurodiverse World

2024–2026 | Substack

Living Lab Blueprint

2018 | Delos Delta

A framework for collaborative urban innovation.

Social Cohesion Index

2018 | UNDP–SeeD

Research contribution to social cohesion measurement.

Multicultural and Secure Urban Areas: The Importance of Social Connectedness in Diverse Global Cities

2017 | SeeD and the Berghof Foundation

Research on social connectedness in diverse cities.

Turkish Islam in the post-colonial context: The Changing Place of Religion in the Turkish Republic

2013 | The Australian Religion Studies Review

Contribution to a special issue on religion and post-colonialism.

Digital storytelling and creative publications

Best in Us / Worst in Us

2020 | Plakkit, Melbourne

COVID public poetry campaign.

Melbourne Connect

2019 | University of Melbourne

Data visualisation films and animated infographics.

Mini Poetry Films

2019

Short-form poetry films.

Public Poetry

2019 | The Poetry Society of New York

Returning Home?

2018 | Digital story

Reverse migration and the experiences of second- and third-generation Australian-Turks in Istanbul.

Engagements

Advisory, Teaching & Public Engagement

City of Melbourne — Arts Grants Panel Member

2020–2024

Contributed to arts funding assessment.

Panel member — Black Awareness Week

Fitzroy Town Hall | 2016

Global Forum on Migration and Development — Civil Society Days

2015 | Logistics and reporting

Coordinated forum logistics and reporting for international migration discussions.

Teaching, workshops and capability development

Academic and public sector settings

Teaching and facilitation across governance, behavioural research, international development, data ethics and responsible technology adoption.

Selected conference contributions

Is Turkey a role model for democratic reform in the Middle East?

University of Melbourne | March 2012

Middle East in Revolt: The First Anniversary.

Looking West, Looking East: The Nexus of Foreign Policy and Identity in Contemporary Turkey

Prato, Italy | June 2011

Globalization, Illiberalism and Islam: Europe and Australia conference.

Islamophobia and Turkophobia in Europe

University of Melbourne | November 2011

CILS / NCEIS Islamic Studies Postgraduate Conference.

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Entrepreneurial

Intellectual Design AU

Research, Digital Strategy & Communications | 2026–Present | Sydney / Remote

Developed during my sabbatical alongside the DEWR initiative, Intellectual Design AU brings together research, AI strategy, digital products and change communications for complex public-sector and organisational challenges.

Consulting focus areas

Research and evaluation

Evidence synthesis · Impact measurement

Research design, policy and program evaluation, indicator development and practical recommendations.

Strategy, governance and change

Organisational development · Responsible AI

Readiness assessments, governance frameworks, stakeholder strategies and implementation planning.

Communications and capability

Research translation · Learning design

Executive briefings, change communications, workshops and learning materials for technical and non-technical audiences.

Digital storytelling, poetry films, projection, installation and public art exploring urban life, migration and social connection.